



UNIVERSITY OF PISA

DEPARTMENT OF INFORMATION ENGINEERING

Master's Degree in Robotics and Automation
Engineering

Navigation System Project
Navigation System Design for HAPS Drone

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Chapter 1

Introduction

The objective of this project is to design, simulate, and validate an integrated Inertial Navigation System (INS) aided by a Global Navigation Satellite System (GNSS). The system architecture, the kinematic models, and the required sensor suite were strictly dictated by a uniquely assigned project code, which outlines a specific set of algorithmic and structural specifications.

1.1 Project Specifications

The system has been developed according to the assigned code D - E - E - G/a - E - PV, which translates to the following architectural choices:

- **D (Decoupled Estimation):** The navigation system features a decoupled architecture. The attitude estimation is performed separately from the position and velocity estimation, utilizing two distinct filtering instances.
- **E (Ellipsoid Earth Model):** The kinematic mechanization assumes an ellipsoidal Earth model (WGS84). The position state is expressed in geodetic coordinates (Latitude, Longitude, Altitude), requiring the dynamic computation of the meridian and transverse radii of curvature (R_M and R_N).
- **E (Euler Angles Parameterization):** The attitude of the vehicle is parameterized within the state vector using Euler angles (Roll, Pitch, Yaw) rather than quaternions.
- **G/a (Sensor Bias Estimation):** The gyroscope bias is actively estimated within the filter state and fed back to correct the raw measurements. Conversely, the accelerometer bias is not estimated, relying solely on the stochastic noise model.

- **E (Attitude Measurements):** The attitude filter exploits direct measurements of the Euler angles, simulating the output of an Attitude and Heading Reference System (AHRS), to correct the inertial integration.
- **PV (Position and Velocity Measurements):** The navigation filter is aided by direct observations of both 3D position and 3D velocity, representing a typical GNSS receiver output in a loosely coupled configuration.

1.2 Operational Scenario and Trajectory Generation

To properly stress the ellipsoidal kinematics and evaluate the filter’s performance over significant Earth-surface displacements, the simulated scenario must involve extended distances and high altitudes. For this reason, the chosen vehicle is a High Altitude Pseudo-Satellite (HAPS), taking the flight characteristics of the Airbus Zephyr as a realistic operational example.

The simulated mission represents a nighttime stratospheric flight with a total duration of 30 minutes (1800 seconds). The vehicle starts at a cruising altitude of 20,000 meters, flying at a highly efficient airspeed of approximately 20 m/s. Due to the massive wingspan and structural constraints typical of HAPS platforms, the generated trajectory is characterized by extremely gentle dynamics, featuring wide turning radii.

Furthermore, to accurately simulate the nighttime power-saving operation, where electric propulsion is minimized in the absence of solar irradiance, a slow and linear altitude loss of 200 meters is distributed over the 30-minute window. This specific scenario highlights the necessity of the WGS84 ellipsoidal model, as a flat-Earth approximation would introduce significant divergence over such extended operational ranges, and provides a challenging dynamic for the vertical channel of the error-state Kalman filter.

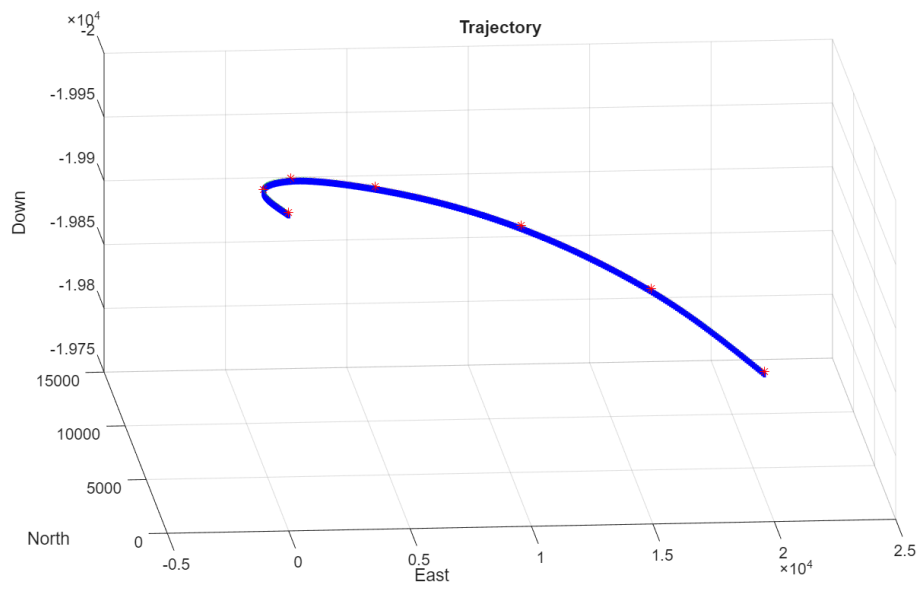


Figure 1.1: Simulated HAPS trajectory in NED frame.

Chapter 2

Inertial Mechanization on the Ellipsoidal Earth

The core of the navigation system is the mechanization algorithm, which integrates the high-frequency measurements provided by the Inertial Measurement Unit (IMU), namely specific forces and angular velocities, to track the vehicle's position, velocity, and attitude. According to the project specifications, the mechanization is formulated over the WGS84 ellipsoidal Earth model, avoiding flat-Earth approximations.

The algorithm is structured into three interconnected modules: position kinematics, attitude update with transport-rate compensation, and gravity compensation.

2.1 Ellipsoidal Position Kinematics

The vehicle's position is expressed in the geodetic coordinate frame (LLH), comprising latitude, longitude, and altitude. To avoid ambiguity with the roll angle, geodetic latitude is denoted here by φ , while longitude and altitude are denoted by λ and h , respectively. Because of the oblateness of the WGS84 ellipsoid, the Earth's radii of curvature are not constant and must be evaluated as functions of the current latitude.

The prime vertical radius of curvature R_N and the meridian radius of curvature R_M are computed at each time step as

$$R_N = \frac{R_e}{\sqrt{1 - e^2 \sin^2 \varphi}} \quad (2.1)$$

$$R_M = R_N \frac{1 - e^2}{1 - e^2 \sin^2 \varphi} \quad (2.2)$$

where $R_e = 6\,378\,137$ m is the semi-major axis and $e \approx 0.0818$ is the first eccentricity of the ellipsoid.

Using the navigation-frame velocities v_N , v_E , and v_D , the LLH kinematic time derivatives are given by

$$\dot{\varphi} = \frac{v_N}{R_M + h} \quad (2.3)$$

$$\dot{\lambda} = \frac{v_E}{(R_N + h) \cos \varphi} \quad (2.4)$$

$$\dot{h} = -v_D \quad (2.5)$$

These derivatives are numerically integrated to propagate the vehicle's geodetic position.

2.2 Attitude Update and Transport-Rate Compensation

The attitude of the vehicle is parameterized using Euler angles, namely roll ϕ , pitch θ , and yaw ψ , which represent the orientation of the body frame with respect to the local NED frame.

The raw angular velocities measured by the gyroscope, $\boldsymbol{\omega}_{ib}^b$, are referenced to the inertial frame. However, the local NED frame is not stationary: it rotates with respect to the inertial frame because of both the Earth's rotation and the motion of the vehicle over the curved Earth surface. This combined rotation is the transport rate, $\boldsymbol{\omega}_{in}^n$, defined as the sum of the Earth rate $\boldsymbol{\omega}_{ie}^n$ and the craft rate $\boldsymbol{\omega}_{en}^n$:

$$\boldsymbol{\omega}_{ie}^n = \begin{bmatrix} \omega_E \cos \varphi \\ 0 \\ -\omega_E \sin \varphi \end{bmatrix} \quad (2.6)$$

$$\boldsymbol{\omega}_{en}^n = \begin{bmatrix} \frac{v_E}{R_N + h} \\ \frac{-v_N}{R_M + h} \\ \frac{-v_E \tan \varphi}{R_N + h} \end{bmatrix} \quad (2.7)$$

$$\boldsymbol{\omega}_{in}^n = \boldsymbol{\omega}_{ie}^n + \boldsymbol{\omega}_{en}^n \quad (2.8)$$

where $\omega_E \approx 7.2921 \times 10^{-5} \text{ rad s}^{-1}$ is the Earth's rotation rate.

To correctly update the vehicle's attitude, the transport rate must be projected into the body frame via the direction cosine matrix C_n^b and subtracted from the raw gyroscope measurements. The corrected body angular rates are then mapped into Euler-angle derivatives using the standard kinematic Jacobian J :

$$\begin{bmatrix} \dot{\phi} \\ \dot{\theta} \\ \dot{\psi} \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & \sin \phi \tan \theta & \cos \phi \tan \theta \\ 0 & \cos \phi & -\sin \phi \\ 0 & \frac{\sin \phi}{\cos \theta} & \frac{\cos \phi}{\cos \theta} \end{bmatrix} (\boldsymbol{\omega}_{ib}^b - C_n^b \boldsymbol{\omega}_{in}^n) \quad (2.9)$$

2.3 Gravity Compensation

The accelerometers measure the specific force $\mathbf{f}^b$, which includes both the kinematic acceleration of the vehicle and the reaction to the Earth's gravitational field. To isolate the true kinematic acceleration needed for the velocity update, the gravity contribution must be subtracted.

Within the WGS84 framework, gravity is not a constant 9.81 m s^{-2} . The mechanization adopts the Somigliana closed-form expression to compute the local gravity magnitude $g(\varphi)$ on the ellipsoid surface as a function of latitude:

$$g(\varphi) = g_{\text{wgs0}} \frac{1 + g_{\text{wgs1}} \sin^2 \varphi}{\sqrt{1 - e^2 \sin^2 \varphi}} \quad (2.10)$$

where $g_{\text{wgs0}} \approx 9.7803 \text{ m s}^{-2}$ is the gravity at the equator and g_{wgs1} is the gravity formula constant. The resulting local gravity vector is

$$\mathbf{g}^n = \begin{bmatrix} 0 & 0 & g(\varphi) \end{bmatrix}^T, \quad (2.11)$$

and is transformed into the body frame and subtracted from the specific-force measurements before the velocity update.

Chapter 3

Sensor Modeling

The accuracy of the navigation filter heavily relies on the realistic modeling of the onboard sensor suite. To simulate a realistic operational environment, the ideal kinematic data was corrupted by introducing stochastic noise and deterministic biases, parameterized based on commercial components. The system integrates a high-frequency (100 Hz) Inertial Measurement Unit (IMU) and a low-frequency (10 Hz) GNSS receiver.

3.1 Inertial Measurement Unit (IMU)

The inertial sensors were modeled using the technical specifications of the 6-axis InvenSense MPU-6050 IMU. Operating at a sampling frequency of $f_s = 100$ Hz, the theoretical noise bandwidth (Nyquist limit) is assumed to be $BW = f_s/2 = 50$ Hz.

3.1.1 Accelerometer Model

From the “Accelerometer Specifications” section of the datasheet, the following parameters are extracted:

- **Full-Scale Range:** $\pm 2g$
- **Noise Power Spectral Density (ND):** $400 \mu g/\sqrt{\text{Hz}}$
- **Initial Zero-G Tolerance (Calibration):** $\pm 50 \text{ mg}$ (X and Y axes), $\pm 80 \text{ mg}$ (Z axis)

In accordance with the **G/a** project specification, the accelerometer bias is not included in the filter’s state vector and is not estimated. The measurement uncertainty is therefore entirely absorbed by the stochastic noise model.

Converting the noise density into the International System of Units yields:

$$ND_{acc} = 400 \cdot 10^{-6} \cdot 9.81 = 0.003924 \text{ m s}^{-2}/\sqrt{\text{Hz}}. \quad (3.1)$$

Assuming white measurement noise, the theoretical standard deviation of the sensor is obtained by multiplying the noise density by the square root of the bandwidth:

$$\sigma_{\text{th},acc} = ND_{acc} \cdot \sqrt{BW} = 0.003924 \cdot \sqrt{50} \approx 0.0277 \text{ m s}^{-2}. \quad (3.2)$$

To ensure the robustness of the Kalman filter, as a conservative approach, and to compensate for the unmodeled bias, high-frequency structural vibrations typical of a large-wingspan HAPS, and mounting misalignments, the nominal standard deviation was increased in the simulator to $\sigma_{acc} = 0.05 \text{ m s}^{-2}$. Consequently, the accelerometer noise covariance matrix $R_{acc} \in \mathbb{R}^{3 \times 3}$ assumes an isotropic diagonal structure:

$$R_{acc} = \text{diag}(\sigma_{acc}^2, \sigma_{acc}^2, \sigma_{acc}^2) = \text{diag}(0.0025, 0.0025, 0.0025) (\text{m s}^{-2})^2. \quad (3.3)$$

3.1.2 Gyroscope Model

From the ‘‘Gyroscope Specifications’’ section, the following values are obtained:

- **Rate Noise Spectral Density (ND):** $0.005^\circ/\text{s}/\sqrt{\text{Hz}}$
- **Initial Zero-Rate Output (ZRO) Tolerance:** $\pm 20^\circ/\text{s}$

Converting the noise density into radians per second yields:

$$ND_{gyro} = 0.005 \cdot \frac{\pi}{180} \approx 8.727 \cdot 10^{-5} \text{ rad s}^{-1}/\sqrt{\text{Hz}}. \quad (3.4)$$

The theoretical standard deviation is calculated by multiplying the noise density by the square root of the bandwidth:

$$\sigma_{\text{th},gyro} = ND_{gyro} \cdot \sqrt{BW} = 8.727 \cdot 10^{-5} \cdot \sqrt{50} \approx 0.000617 \text{ rad s}^{-1}. \quad (3.5)$$

Similar to the accelerometer model, this theoretical standard deviation reflects ideal laboratory conditions. During real flight operations, the sensor is exposed to structural vibrations, temperature-induced drifts, and mechanical noise that increase the actual uncertainty. To adopt a conservative approach and ensure the filter does not over-trust the inertial measurements, the simulated standard deviation was increased to $\sigma_{gyro} = 0.003 \text{ rad s}^{-1}$.

Regarding the deterministic error, the datasheet declares an initial ZRO tolerance of $\pm 20^\circ/\text{s}$, which mathematically corresponds to an error of $\pm 0.349 \text{ rad s}^{-1}$. However, it is standard practice to assume that the vehicle undergoes a pre-flight static calibration procedure to estimate and remove the bulk of this gross initial offset. The bias values injected into the simulation, $\mathbf{b}_{gyro} = [0.005, -0.003, 0.006]^T \text{ rad s}^{-1}$, represent the small uncalibrated residual bias. In accordance with the **G/a** specification, the filter dynamically estimates this residual bias during the flight to correct the raw measurements.

3.2 Attitude and Heading Reference System (AHRS)

To estimate the aircraft's attitude, the decoupled system uses direct measurements of the Euler angles. The reference sensor chosen for this simulation is the VectorNav VN-100, a miniature high-performance AHRS module.

From the performance specifications section of the datasheet, the following accuracy values are extracted:

- **Pitch/Roll Accuracy (Dynamic):** 1.0° RMS
- **Magnetic Heading/Yaw Accuracy:** 2.0° RMS
- **Attitude Output Data Rate:** up to 400 Hz

The RMS values provided by the manufacturer were assumed as nominal standard deviations for the measurement noise. To integrate them into the error-state Kalman filter, these values were converted into radians:

$$\sigma_{\text{roll/pitch}} = 1.0 \cdot \frac{\pi}{180} \approx 0.0174 \text{ rad} \quad (3.6)$$

$$\sigma_{\text{yaw}} = 2.0 \cdot \frac{\pi}{180} \approx 0.0349 \text{ rad} \quad (3.7)$$

Since the Euler angles are measured independently, the attitude measurement error covariance matrix assumes a diagonal form:

$$R_{\text{ahrs}} = \text{diag}(\sigma_{\text{roll/pitch}}^2, \sigma_{\text{roll/pitch}}^2, \sigma_{\text{yaw}}^2) \text{ rad}^2. \quad (3.8)$$

3.3 Global Navigation Satellite System (GNSS)

The navigation block requires absolute position and velocity measurements to bound the intrinsic drift of the inertial integration. The receiver modeled in the system is the u-blox NEO-M8N module.

From the commercial component's specifications, the following key parameters are highlighted:

- **Maximum Navigation Update Rate:** 10 Hz
- **Horizontal Position Accuracy (Autonomous):** 2.5 m CEP
- **Velocity Accuracy:** 0.05 m s^{-1}

Since the positional state vector is expressed in WGS84 geodetic coordinates, the planimetric variance must be converted into radians by normalizing it against the Earth's radius R_e :

$$\sigma_{\text{pos,horiz}}^2 = \left(\frac{2.5}{R_e}\right)^2 \text{ rad}^2. \quad (3.9)$$

Regarding the vertical axis, GNSS altitude is typically degraded by worse geometric dilution of precision and uncompensable tropospheric delays. For this reason, the altitude standard deviation was conservatively set to 3.5 m in the simulator.

The three-dimensional velocity measurements, derived by the receiver through carrier-phase Doppler shift analysis, maintain the nominal datasheet value, with a standard deviation of $\sigma_{\text{vel}} = 0.05 \text{ m s}^{-1}$.

The GNSS measurement covariance matrix is then built by assembling the position and velocity variances:

$$R_{\text{gps}} = \text{diag}(\sigma_{\text{pos,horiz}}^2, \sigma_{\text{pos,horiz}}^2, 3.5^2, \sigma_{\text{vel}}^2, \sigma_{\text{vel}}^2, \sigma_{\text{vel}}^2). \quad (3.10)$$